

The Complete Windows 11 Customization Guide

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The Complete Windows 11 Customization Guide

Every tool, setting, and fix from the 24-Hour Ricing Video

The video shows what's possible. This guide shows exactly how to do it, every setting, every workaround, every "why didn't this work" moment, spelled out. Organized by the same three tiers: 1 Hour, 10 Hours, 24 Hours.

Work through it in order, later tiers assume earlier tools are installed. Each tier starts with a System Restore Point, don't skip it.

How to Read This Guide

- **[INSTALL COMMAND]**, wherever you see this tag, there's a ready-to-run command right under it. Open PowerShell or Windows Terminal, paste the command, hit Enter, and that app installs itself, no browser, no download folder, no installer wizard.
- **Direct download / Microsoft Store links in this guide are accurate as of July 16, 2026.** App pages get renamed, moved, or replaced after updates, so a link here can go stale. If a link 404s or looks wrong, the app's own official website is always the

most reliable place to find the current download, search for the app name directly rather than trusting an old link.

- **New to installing things from GitHub?** Read “How to Download From GitHub” in the next section before you start, most of Tier 2 and Tier 3 lean on it.

Quick install: core winget commands

Copy-paste the block for whichever tier you’re setting up. IDs with a Store source install from the Microsoft Store; everything else pulls from winget’s default source.

Tier 1

```
winget install --id Microsoft.PowerToys -e
winget install --id CharlesMilette.TranslucentTB -e
winget install --id 9P8LTPGCBZXD --source msstore # WinToys
```

Tier 2

```
winget install --id MartiCliment.UniGetUI -e
winget install --id 9NTSNMSVCB5L --source msstore # Screenbox
winget install --id Microsoft.DotNet.DesktopRuntime.8 -e
winget install --id zhongyang219.TrafficMonitor -e
winget install --id rocksdanister.LivelyWallpaper -e
winget install --id Microsoft.VisualStudioCode -e
winget install --id LGUG2Z.komorebi -e
winget install --id LGUG2Z.whkd -e
winget install --id AmN.yasb -e
```

Tier 3

```
winget install --id MicaForEveryone.MicaForEveryone -e
winget install --id Microsoft.WindowsTerminal -e
winget install --id Nilessoft.Shell -e
winget install --id RamenSoftware.Windhawk -e
winget install --id valinet.ExplorerPatcher -e
winget install --id Abdelrhman-AK.WinPaletter -e
winget install --id Rainmeter.Rainmeter -e
winget install --id qBittorrent.qBittorrent -e
winget install --id OBSProject.OBSStudio -e
```

Anything without a clean winget ID (File Pilot, Accent Colorizer, Tacky Borders, Zen Browser, and a handful of others) is installed manually, the exact download link is under each tool below.

Before You Start

- **Create a System Restore Point every tier.** Search “Create a restore point” → System Protection tab → if disabled, click Configure → turn on protection → set max usage to ~10% → Apply → OK. Then click “Create,” name it something you’ll recognize later (e.g. “Before 10hr Section”).
- **Have a spare partition or dual-boot install if you’re going deep.** Several tools here ([Explorer Patcher](#), [Windhawk](#), [Rectify11](#), [SeelenUI](#)) can break Explorer or

corrupt system files. Testing on a separate Windows install/partition is the safe way to follow this guide.

- **Keep 15–20GB of free disk space at minimum.** You will run out. Plan for it, especially before Tier 3.
- **Tools referenced generally live in three places:** the Microsoft Store, direct GitHub Releases pages, or via a package manager ([UniGetUI](#), installed in Tier 2).
- **A baseline reference point, for comparison:** a clean Windows 11 install with just a screen recorder running typically sits around 147 processes, 10–15% CPU, and ~17% memory at idle (GPU usage will be higher than that, but mostly attributable to the recorder itself, not Windows). If you’re starting meaningfully higher than that before installing anything from this guide, it’s worth checking what’s already running in the background first.

How to Download From GitHub

Most of the tools in Tier 2 and Tier 3 come straight from GitHub instead of the Microsoft Store, so it’s worth knowing the pattern once instead of re-figuring it out per tool:

1. **Check for a “Releases” page first.** On the repo’s main page, look in the right-hand sidebar for a “Releases” section, or go directly to `github.com/<owner>/<repo>/releases`. This is where the actual built, ready-to-run app lives.
2. **Open the latest release and look under “Assets.”** This is a collapsed list at the bottom of the release notes, click it to expand. You want a file like `AppName-win-x64.zip`, `AppName-Setup.exe`, or `AppName.msi`. Most modern PCs are x64 (or x86_64), only pick arm64 if you know you’re on an ARM-based Windows device.
3. **If there’s no Releases page at all,** the project may not ship prebuilt binaries, check the README for install instructions first. As a last resort, the green **Code** button → **Download ZIP** downloads the raw source code, not a runnable app; only use this if the README specifically tells you to.
4. **Extract the zip before running anything inside it.** Windows will sometimes refuse to run an `.exe` directly from inside a zip window.
5. **Expect Windows SmartScreen or Defender to flag unsigned tools** (“Windows protected your PC,” or a silent delete from your Downloads folder). This is common for small open-source apps that haven’t paid for a code-signing certificate, not a sign the tool is actually malicious. But always match the download to the repo’s own official releases page, and check “Assets” upload counts and the release date to avoid impersonation repos. Recovery steps for both cases are covered inline throughout this guide wherever they come up (see Tier 3, step 23, for the fullest walkthrough).

TIER 1: The One-Hour Setup (High Impact, Low Risk)

Everything here is safe, reversible, and worth doing even if you stop after this section.

1. Sharper Display via Nvidia DSR (or AMD/Intel equivalent)

1. Open [Nvidia Control Panel](#) → Manage 3D Settings.
2. Scroll to DSR – Factors, check the 4x (4K) option.
3. Set DSR – Smoothness to ~20%. Apply.
4. Go to Change Resolution → Dynamic Super Resolution, select the new 3840×2160 option. Apply → confirm.
5. Your native monitor resolution stays the same (e.g. 1920×1080), Windows now renders at 4K and scales down, producing sharper text and UI edges.
6. Gotcha: After enabling, the [Nvidia Control Panel](#) window itself may render tiny/broken. Close and reopen it to fix.
7. Go to Settings → Display → Scale, bump to 250% (trade-off: less screen real estate fits, everything is physically bigger).
8. Back in [Nvidia Control Panel](#) → Adjust Desktop Color Settings → bump Digital Vibrance to ~75%. Note: this only affects your physical monitor, not screen recordings/screenshots.

(No Nvidia GPU: AMD Radeon Software has “Custom Resolution/GPU Scaling”; Intel Arc Control has similar scaling options, the DSR-equivalent naming differs but the render-at-higher-res-then-scale-down concept is the same.)

2. Wallpaper, Timeline Wallpaper

1. Install [Timeline Wallpaper](#) (Microsoft Store).
INSTALL COMMAND: `winget install --id 9N7VHQ989BB7 --source msstore`
2. Browse curated wallpapers with arrow keys.
3. Right-click → Settings → Choose from the curated packs like “Timeline Weekly” or “Timeline Trending. I disabled categories i don’t want (e.g. anime/“CHP”, “Girl”), kept general photography/nature/architecture sets.
4. Right-click your chosen wallpaper → Set as Desktop.
5. Fix wallpaper compression: Windows compresses desktop backgrounds to ~85% quality by default. Install [WinToys](#) → Tweaks tab → Desktop → set the wallpaper quality slider from 85% up to 100%. Requires a restart to take effect. ([WinToys](#) is a broader all-in-one tweaking utility, not just a wallpaper fix, worth a look at its other tabs too.)
6. Alternatives if Timeline Wallpaper doesn’t fit your taste: [backiee](#), [MyerSplash](#), or [Lively Wallpaper](#) (used later in Tier 2 for animated wallpapers).

3. Custom Cursor

1. Search GitHub / DeviantArt for a Windows-native cursor pack.
2. Recommended: “[Vision Cursor](#)” on GitHub → go to the Releases page → download the “.zip” file.
3. Extract the zip. Right-click the .inf file → Show more options → Install.

4. Open Settings → Bluetooth & devices → Mouse → Additional mouse settings (or search “Mouse Pointer Size”) → Pointers tab → select the newly installed cursor scheme → Apply.
5. Sizing gotcha: the pointer-size slider in Settings only resizes the default Windows cursor, not custom ones. To make a custom cursor bigger:
 - First, increase the default cursor size in Settings (e.g. set it to 4).
 - Then go back to Mouse Properties → Pointers tab and re-select your custom cursor scheme. It will inherit the larger size.
- Alternative source: the “[Custom Cursor](#)” website/app has more cursors and also lets you rotate between multiple cursors on a timer (every few seconds up to once a day), which is a nice extra if you want variety.

4. Widgets Panel Cleanup

1. Open the Widgets panel (taskbar icon or Win+W).
2. Settings (gear icon) → turn OFF “Open widgets on hover.”
3. Turn off the news feed toggle.
4. Remove unwanted widgets (Markets, etc.) by clicking the “...” on each widget card → Remove.

5. Core Windows Settings Tweaks

Settings → System → Multitasking:

- Snap suggestions and snap layouts: hover over maximize button, drag to top of screen.
- “Show tabs from apps when snapping / Alt+Tab” → set to “Don’t show tabs” to hide browser tabs from alt tab menu.
- Title bar window shake: grab a window’s title bar and shake it → minimizes all other windows. (Settings → System → Multitasking → Titlebar window shake).

Settings → System → For developers:

- Enable “End Task”, lets you right-click any app in the taskbar and kill it without opening Task Manager.

File Explorer → View → Options (three-dot menu → Options → View tab):

- Enable “File name extensions.”
- Enable long path support: run gpedit.msc → Computer Configuration → Administrative Templates → System → Filesystem → “Enable Win32 long paths” → Enabled. (Or via registry: HKLM= 1.)

A few more worth doing:

Clipboard: Settings → System → Clipboard → turn ON Clipboard history. Access anytime with Win+V.

Taskbar: Settings → Personalization → Taskbar → Search box → set to icon only.

Start Menu: Right-click Start → Start Settings → turn OFF “Show recently added apps,” “Show recommended files,” “Show most used apps.” Enable Settings / File Explorer / Downloads folder shortcuts to appear on the Start menu.

In Advanced System Settings → Performance Options, select “Adjust for best appearance.” Apply.

6. PowerToys (Microsoft)

Install from the Microsoft Store or GitHub Releases.

- **[INSTALL COMMAND]** `winget install --id Microsoft.PowerToys -e`

- Power Display: quick brightness slider from the system tray.
- Light Switch: automatically toggles dark/light theme at sunrise/sunset. If your PC can't auto-detect location (no GPS), get your coordinates manually: open Google Maps, copy your location code → ask AI to extract the latitude and longitude → paste into Light Switch's settings. Default hotkey to manually toggle theme: Win+Ctrl+Shift+D.
- Command Palette (default hotkey Win+Alt+Space): a unified launcher for apps, files, web search, and commands, extensible with extensions.
 - In Command Palette settings, enable the Dock: an always-visible bar (macOS-dock-style) pinned to the top of the screen.
 - Right-click any command inside Command Palette → “Pin to Dock” to add it (clipboard history, web search, weather, etc. are good starting picks).
 - You can reposition and lock the dock (e.g., left-aligned).

7. TranslucentTB

1. Install [TranslucentTB](#) (Microsoft Store or GitHub). **[INSTALL COMMAND]** `winget install --id CharlesMilette.TranslucentTB -e`
2. Launch, taskbar becomes translucent instantly.
3. In its tray settings, set the effect mode to Blur.

End state after Tier 1: 4K-upscaled sharp UI, custom wallpaper + cursor, decluttered widgets, key settings tweaked, PowerToys Command Palette dock running, translucent taskbar.

TIER 2: The Ten-Hour Setup (Deeper, Some Risk)

 Create a System Restore Point before starting this tier (see “Before You Start”).

8. Debloating, WinUtil

1. Open Terminal as Administrator, make sure you're on the Windows PowerShell tab.
2. Paste the install command from [WinUtil's](#) GitHub page: `irm https://christitus.com/win | iex`

3. Tweaks tab (Standard preset covers most of this): disable telemetry/tracking, disable activity history, enable “End Task” in right-click (redundant if you did it in Tier 1), disable temp files, remove pre-installed bloat apps, enable verbose boot/login messages, disable Start Menu Bing search and Start Menu recommendations.
4. Config tab: enable the registry backup option before running tweaks, in case something needs reverting.
5. Updates tab: select the “Security” profile, delays feature updates by roughly a year, and installs security patches after a short ~4-day delay rather than the moment they’re available (still far faster than feature updates, just not literally immediate).
6. Click “Run Tweaks” (easy to configure everything and forget this step, nothing applies until you do).
7. ⚠️ Known side effect: the Standard debloat list can remove built in apps you need.
8. After restart, the start menu will revert to the previous layout before it got updated. You can revert it in the tweaks tabs by selecting “Start Menu Previous Layout – Enable” and pressing the “Undo Selected Tweaks” button.
9. To revert any single [WinUtil](#) tweak later: search for it by name in WinUtil (e.g. “start”) → select it → click “Undo Selected Tweaks.”
10. Digital Markets Act (DMA) toggle (EU-only feature, forces Microsoft to allow uninstalling Edge, disables full-screen ads): found under [Wintoys](#) Tweaks → System tab. Enable → restart → verify. Known issue: this frequently fails to apply even after multiple restarts and re-toggles, with no clear fix. If it doesn’t work, it’s not just you, treat it as low priority. Full list of changes: [Windows Blogs](#)

9. App Replacements

9. App Replacements

Remove what you don’t need first, Camera, Microsoft 365/Copilot, OneDrive, Remote Desktop Connection, Xbox Live, etc., via Settings → Apps → Installed apps → Uninstall, or through WinUtil’s uninstall list.

Install replacements:

- [Screenbox](#) (Microsoft Store), a VLC-based media player that replaces Photos/Media Player for video. **[INSTALL COMMAND]:** `winget install --id 9NTSNMSVCB5L --source msstore`
- [UniGetUI](#) (formerly WingetUI, GitHub or direct site), which replaces the Microsoft Store as your app manager. Updates every installed app, Store and non-Store, in one click. You’ll use this as your primary installer for the rest of the guide. **[INSTALL COMMAND]:** `winget install --id MartiCliment.UniGetUI -e` > **Tip:** `winget upgrade --all` in Terminal does the same thing as UniGetUI’s batch-update button. UniGetUI is really the GUI for people who want to see what’s changing and approve it, rather than trust a one-line command to silently update everything, set it

to notify on startup and batch-approve once a week instead of daily, so you're not interrupted mid-task by update prompts.

- [File Pilot](#), a File Explorer replacement. During setup: keep the defaults, set it as the default file manager, add it to PATH, and click Install. Customize the font size (try 11, up from the default) and color/accent scheme (the "Pollux" preset is a solid pick) in its settings.
 - Speed is the headline feature: tab switching and view switching are near-instant, with smooth animations. The entire app's install footprint is around 2MB, smaller than a typical PNG image.
 - Currently free while in beta; will become a paid app once it exits beta.
 - Gap: File Pilot doesn't currently have a "Group By" option in its views, if you rely on grouping files (e.g. by type or date) in the native File Explorer, that workflow doesn't carry over.

10. Desktop Accessories

- [Desktop Pets](#): Install → New Pet → choose Goose as the pet type → name it (e.g. "Clippy") → pick a personality (e.g. Grumpy) → Create. Purely cosmetic/fun.
- [Fliqlo](#) screensaver: download from screensaversplanet.com or fliqlo.com. Unzip, right-click the .scr file → Install. The install triggers the Windows screensaver settings panel, set the idle timeout there (Settings → Personalization → Lock screen → Screen saver settings). Note: screensavers won't trigger during active screen recording/heavy foreground use, this is expected, not a bug.

11. Taskbar Tools

- [Task Separator 11](#) (GitHub), adds visual dividers between taskbar icon groups. Requires the [.NET Desktop Runtime](#) (download from Microsoft if prompted). After install, open the app → "Create Separator" → right-click the new separator icon → Pin to Taskbar → drag into position. Repeat to add multiple separators.
- [RoundedTB](#) (GitHub), rounds taskbar corners. ⚠ Last updated Nov 2021, archived Sep 2023, no longer maintained, use at your own risk. Enable the Advanced tab → "Fill Taskbar when Maximized" so corners go flat/full when a window is maximized, rounded otherwise.
- [Traffic Monitor](#) (GitHub, x64 build). **[INSTALL COMMAND]**: `winget install --id zhongyang219.TrafficMonitor -e`. Shows CPU/GPU/network/disk stats by hovering the taskbar tray icon. Right-click its icon → "Show taskbar window" → uncheck the floating main window if you only want the taskbar hover view. Redundant if you're also using the PowerToys Command Palette dock or [yasb](#) (Tier 2/3) for system stats, pick one.
- [ElevenClock](#) (GitHub, same developer as UniGetUI), replaces the default taskbar clock. Setup wizard covers:
 - Full-screen behavior: hide the clock when a full-screen window (video, game) is active, matches default Windows behavior, safe choice.

- Date/time format: toggle seconds, date-only view, week number, time-only view, weekday display.
- Appearance presets: several built-in visual styles to start from, Windows 95, black and white, accent color, MS-DOS, pick whichever fits your overall theme, or use one as a starting point before customizing further.
- Deeper appearance customization (separate from the presets): custom font selection (try a serif font at a larger size, e.g. 12pt, bold, for a distinct look), custom highlight/accent colors, and more.

12. Desktop Widgets

- [UWidgets](#) (beta release, GitHub), needs the Microsoft Windows Desktop Runtime (a .NET dependency; download when prompted, same requirement as Task Separator 11 above). Add widgets: a month calendar, a separate date calendar, a clock, a notes widget, reminders, and weather forecast. Enable “Run on Startup.” Set it to “follow system theme” for automatic dark/light switching, and dial opacity down to around 0.6.
- [Widget Launcher](#) (Microsoft Store), has more widget variety than UWidgets but injects an unskippable ad before every single widget opens, tested on both a Calculator widget and a CPU meter widget, both gated behind ads.

13. System-Wide Accent Color

- [Accent Colorizer](#) (GitHub), colorizes the selection/highlight box to match your Windows accent color. Download [AccentColorizer-Installer.zip](#). Edge/SmartScreen will likely flag the download as “isn’t commonly downloaded”, right-click the download → Keep → run the .exe → right-click → Keep again if prompted a second time. Extract the installer zip and run `install.cmd`; the success message is literally “Accent colorizer successfully installed.”
- [Accent Colorizer 11](#) (GitHub, same author/family), colorizes File Explorer’s command bar icons to match your accent color. Download [AccentColorizer-E11.exe](#) and restart File Explorer (or sign out/in) to see the change take effect.
- Set your accent color: Settings → Personalization → Colors → Accent Color.

14. Media & Volume Flyouts

Install “[Fluent Flyout](#)” (note: there’s also a similarly named app, “[Fluent Flyouts](#)” with an “S,” that only adds a retro analog clock overlay, skip that one, and get the one without the S for full media control features). Settings worth knowing, by tab:

- **Home tab:** configure the media flyout, background style (try “None” for the cleanest look; other options include Cover, Blur, Rising Glow, and Blur combined), compact layout toggle (default/non-compact was preferred), flyout position (bottom left was the pick), whether it stays open until manually closed (“Always display,” left off), enable “Show Media Player Name,” and repeat/shuffle button visibility. The interactive seek bar carries an asterisk in the app’s own settings: not

all apps/browsers support seek, repeat, or shuffle this way. Microsoft Edge + YouTube worked.

- **Volume flyout tab:** the per-app volume mixer can be positioned above the media flyout instead of below, tested, not preferred.
- **Next Up flyout tab:** shows a preview of what's coming up next, but only triggers when a track/video advances automatically; manually pressing next/previous brings up the standard media flyout instead.
- **Lock Keys flyout tab:** shows an on-screen indicator when you toggle Caps Lock (and Num Lock / Scroll Lock, if your keyboard has those keys), genuinely useful if you've ever wondered whether Caps Lock silently turned on.
- **System tab:** album art as accent color is an optional toggle that dynamically shifts your system accent color to match whatever album art/thumbnail is currently playing. Disabled in the end, striking as a demo, but it fights with having a deliberately chosen static accent color everywhere else in the setup.
- **Taskbar Visualizer tab:** premium features (paid tier) include a compact taskbar-embedded mini player widget and a taskbar audio visualizer showing which apps are currently outputting sound.

Two alternatives tested and passed over, in case you want to compare yourself: “[Media Flyout](#)” (lets you manage playback sessions and remotely control compatible apps, with a large now-playing view and play queue, functional, just ultimately less preferred) and “[Modern Flyouts](#)” (despite the name, looked less modern than Fluent Flyout in side-by-side testing). Fluent Flyout won both comparisons.

- [TopNotify](#) moves notification toasts to a custom position. Default behavior is bottom-right; top-right was the pick that stuck. You can drag notifications to any custom position on screen, including dead center, and adjust their transparency (default level was kept). Custom sounds: enable custom notification sounds and pick from the built-in list, the “Notify 7” sound was chosen specifically for a nostalgic Windows 7 feel. Send yourself a test notification after setting this up to confirm it's actually applying before moving on.
- Alternative tested and rejected: “[Modern Notify](#)” (Microsoft Store), which bills itself as a full action-center replacement rather than just a notification-position tool. In testing it defaulted to a non-English UI (a language switch is available in-app), felt noticeably laggy, and didn't offer enough over the others to justify keeping. Uninstalled.
- [Calendar Flyout](#) brings back the old Windows 10-style interactive calendar that appears when you click the taskbar clock, letting you add calendar events directly from the flyout without opening a separate Calendar app. ⚠️ Unlike most of the other flyout tools in this section, this one is a paid app, factor that in before committing to it.
- [Live Tiles Anywhere](#) brings back Windows 10-style Live Tiles to the Windows 11 desktop.

- Custom Tile workflow: click “Create New Custom Tile” → point it at a website (e.g. a Google Docs link) to pin as a live tile.
- Known rough edge: custom web tiles frequently come through with no icon. Workaround: right-click the tile → Edit → search for and save the site’s icon online → add it under the tile’s Badge section as a picture file → if the file extension doesn’t match what the tool expects, manually rename it to .png → click Test Run / Execute to confirm it applies → Save.
- More reliable alternative path: instead of building a custom tile from scratch, go to the “On Apps” section within Live Tiles Anywhere and pick from tiles apps have already registered, e.g. the [Fluent Weather](#) app (installed earlier in Tier 2) exposes its own live weather tile here. Right-click it → “Create a desktop icon” or “Create a widget” for a working live weather tile with no icon hassle.
- Later removed in Tier 3 for being redundant once other weather-checking options were already running, worth keeping in mind that this is a “nice to try” tool rather than something you necessarily keep long-term once your build has multiple weather sources.

15. Animated Wallpaper

- [Lively Wallpaper](#) (same developer as Fluent Weather). **[INSTALL COMMAND]:**
`winget install --id rocksdanister.LivelyWallpaper -e`. A broad built-in library worth actually browsing rather than picking the first option. Wallpapers tested, with real reactions, in case you want a shortlist to start from:
 - Fluid, a fluid simulation that trails behind your cursor. Genuinely fun to interact with, if a bit of a novelty.
 - Living Room, a rendered 3D living room scene. Noticeably heavier on system resources than the others.
 - Music, displays the currently-playing song’s album art as the wallpaper.
 - Medusa, passed over as too basic/plain.
 - Parallax.js, a simple parallax-depth effect. Landed as the final pick: simple, cool, and light on resources.
 - Rain, a customizable rain effect.
 - Matrix-style falling-code wallpaper, and a couple of others not worth detailing individually.
- [Sucrose](#), a competing app with a much larger built-in wallpaper store, including animated clocks and more elaborate scenes. Worth trying specifically for the sheer size of its library if Lively’s selection doesn’t have what you want.
- ⚠ Resource warning: animated/3D wallpapers, especially heavier ones in Sucrose, can spike CPU to 100%+ (132% CPU was observed in testing) and cause fan ramp-up, particularly while also running a screen recorder. If you notice sustained high CPU/fan noise, drop back to a simpler wallpaper or Lively’s lighter effects (Parallax.js) instead of Sucrose’s heavier scenes.

16. Custom System Sounds

- [Sound Manager](#) (GitHub) lets you assign a sound to every Windows action (logon, error, warning, app launch, etc.), or apply a full pre-made sound scheme. Scheme packs download to your Music folder during first setup, pick from themes like Windows Vista/7 (a strong, nostalgic default), Discord, Xbox 360, Animal Crossing, Among Us, etc.
- Optional companion: keyboard/mouse sound effects via [Mechvibes](#) or [Thockly](#) (paid, free trial) for per-keystroke mechanical-keyboard sounds, mouse click sounds, and scroll sounds.

17. Folder Icons, Expect This to Fail

- [Folder 11](#) is the obvious tool, 1,400+ community icons in its own tab, plus a built-in icon maker for building custom ones. Both paths were tested and both ultimately failed to apply:
 - Community icons: a couple of popular picks from the community tab returned “Failed to apply icons. Please try again.”
 - Built-in icon maker: a macOS-style folder template with a dark purple folder color, an [OBS Studio](#) logo layered on top (resized, opacity adjusted), and a text label positioned under the icon, a genuinely nice-looking result in the preview. Clicking “Apply to folder” still failed with the same generic error.
 - The app’s own suggested fixes (“Show Edit with 11 in Windows” context menu integration, “Enable auto rebuild icon cache”) didn’t resolve it either.
 - Exporting the icon as a file does work, even though applying it directly to a folder doesn’t, so if you want to salvage something from the time spent in the icon maker, export your custom design and apply it manually via the classic method below.
- Don’t spend more than a few minutes on it. There’s currently no fully reliable free tool for this. The classic manual method (right-click folder → Properties → Customize → Change Icon → pick a .ico file) still works for individual folder icons without a dedicated app, it’s worth using Folder 11’s icon maker purely to design and export an icon, then applying that exported .ico the classic way instead of fighting with Folder 11’s own Apply button.

18. Context Menu Cleanup

Two separate tools handle two separate menus:

- “[Windows 11 Context Menu Manager](#)” (different from the classic tool below) controls the modern Windows 11 right-click menu. Download the [Win-x64.zip](#) release directly from its GitHub Releases page, extract it, and run the .exe. After disabling items (e.g. “Creative Designer,” OneDrive entries), you must restart the Explorer process via Task Manager for changes to actually apply, disabling alone, without the Explorer restart, will look like nothing happened.

- “[Context Menu Manager](#)” controls the classic right-click menu (the one under “Show more options”). Download [ContextMenuManager.zip](#). First run will prompt that your system display language isn’t Simplified Chinese and ask if you want to download another language, say yes, pick English (US), and restart when it asks. Go tab by tab (File / Folder / Directory / Background / Desktop / Drive / All Objects / Library) disabling unused entries:
 - File: disabled “Add to Favorites,” “File Ownership,” “Give Access,” “Work Folders.”
 - Folder: left as-is, no changes needed.
 - Directory: disabled “Encryption,” “Give Access,” “Work Folders,” “Restore Previous Versions,” “Always Available Offline.”
 - Background (right-click empty desktop/folder space): disabled the Nvidia Control Panel entry (never opened it this way, it’s opened from the system tray instead), plus “Give Access” and “Work Folders.”
 - Desktop: disabled “Display Settings” and “Personalize.”
 - Drive (disk): disabled “Give Access” and “File Locksmith.”
 - All Objects: disabled “Share,” “Send To” (the whole submenu, if you don’t use quick-send targets), and “Always Available Offline.”
 - Library: disabled “Send To” and “Give Access.”
 - There are also dedicated sub-tabs for customizing the “New” submenu, the “Send To” submenu specifically, and the “Open With” submenu, if you want more granular control over any of those individually.
 - The most useful feature is easy to miss: “Menu Analysis.” If you’re not sure which tab controls a specific unwanted item, use this instead of guessing tab by tab: click Menu Analysis → select a representative file of the type you’re troubleshooting (e.g. a .png) → it identifies every category that file’s context menu actually pulls items from, for an image file, that’s the general File context menu, All Objects, the specific file type (.png), and the perceived file type (“image file”) category. This is how to track down where to look when an item like “Creative Designer” doesn’t show up where expected, in that specific case, it turned out not to exist in CMM at all (it lives in the other tool, Windows 11 Context Menu Manager, above), which Menu Analysis is what confirmed.
 - File Types tab (for image files specifically): disable “Print” and “Cast to Device.”
 - Add useful items under the “Other rules” tab: “Copy Content to Clipboard,” “Take Ownership,” “Restart Explorer,” “Wallpaper Location,” “Screensaver Settings,” “Permanently Delete,” “Clean Thumbnail Cache.”
 - “Send to My Phone” removal is a dead end. It doesn’t live in either context menu tool. Things that don’t work: [NirSoft ShellExView](#), disabling the “Portable Device” shell extension, Group Policy Editor (no matching policy

under File Explorer settings), or another tool called [Custom Context Menu](#). There's currently no reliable removal method, skip it.

19. Start Menu Replacement, Pick One

Test both, but don't run them simultaneously, they conflict.

Start 11 (Stardock):

- ⚠ Note upfront: Start 11 is a paid app with a 30-day trial, not free like most of the rest of this list. - Setup wizard: choose Start button position (left/center) and a style (Windows 7 / Modern / Win10-with-improvements / Win11-with-improvements / Windows Launcher), each with sub-variants (compact, grid, etc.), the full sub-style list includes compact, grid, compact-grid, "with icons on the side," and "grid with icons." Windows 7 style with the compact sub-style was the pick that stuck.
- Notable settings: Mica background effect, a taskbar icon size setting with several presets (Smart, Small-with-wide-icon-spacing, Extra Large, Medium was kept as the best balance), a Combined/Uncombined icons toggle, and a Taskbar Pins feature that lets you pin a folder (e.g. Downloads) directly to the taskbar as a flyout you can drag files out of.
- Also brings a genuinely more useful taskbar right-click menu, restoring older actions like "Cascade Windows," "Show Windows Stacked," and "Show Windows Side by Side" that Windows 10 had and Windows 11 dropped.
- Start 11's own search is noticeably better than the native Windows 11 Start Menu search.

Start All Back:

- Settings live in Control Panel (search "Start All Back"), not a normal Settings page.
- Start Menu tab: icon size, flyout style, sort order, hover-to-open submenus, search flyout behavior. - Right-side folder shortcuts: set folders (e.g. Downloads, Videos) to display as a drag-and-drop menu instead of a static link.
- Taskbar tab: centers pinned icons while keeping the Start button pinned left (a layout Windows 11 doesn't offer natively); enable Dynamic Transparency (taskbar goes transparent with no window behind it, opaque when one is).
- File Explorer tab: switch to the Windows 10 ribbon UI, enable Mica effect, new icons, colorize with accent color, bottom details pane, restore classic Control Panel applets, use new fonts for classic UI.
- Bonus: gives Control Panel itself a dark theme, which Windows 11 doesn't natively support.

Conflict resolution: if you install both to compare, fully uninstall the one you're not keeping (disabling isn't enough, Start 11 in particular keeps applying its theme even when "disabled"). After uninstalling, restart.

20. Tiling Window Manager, Komorebi

Why Komorebi over [GlazeWM](#): GlazeWM is more beginner-friendly with a built-in status bar; Komorebi is faster/lighter and better suited for complex, heavily customized layouts (paired with a separate status bar like yasb).

Install:

[INSTALL COMMANDS]:

```
winget install LGUG2Z.komorebi -e
```

```
winget install LGUG2Z.whkd -e
```

Config paths (Paste in File Explorer Address Bar)

%USERPROFILE%\komorebi.json

%USERPROFILE%\komorebi.bar.json

%USERPROFILE%\applications.json

%USERPROFILE%\config\whkdrc.

Resources:

Komorebi docs/wiki: <https://lgug2z.github.io/komorebi/>.

Komorebi NotebookLM notebook: <https://notebooklm.google.com/notebook/14a8e857-d6e4-4eb5-b715-e4ee8157a53e>.

Komorebi Youtube Playlist:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cBnLlwMtv8g&list=PLlIZnrEJu89AJzPSvO7racNyfvPmJupkx>

My config: [komorebi.json](#)

Setup:

1. Enable Windows long-path support first (see Tier 1, File Explorer tweaks, same registry/gpedit setting).

Komorebi long path prep

Run in Administrator PowerShell before installing Komorebi.

```
Set-ItemProperty 'HKLM:\SYSTEM\CurrentControlSet\Control\FileSystem' -Name 'LongPathsEnabled' -Value 1
```

2. Disable unnecessary system animations: Control Panel → Ease of Access Center → “Turn off all unnecessary animations (when possible)” → Apply.
3. Install via winget (Komorebi supports it directly).
4. If SmartScreen blocks the executable: More info → Run anyway.

5. Search for komorebi.exe to launch, then in the terminal type “komorebic quickstart” to pull example configs
6. Run “komorebic start --whkd --bar” in the terminal to launch komrebi

Core keybinds (default modifier: ALT):

Action	Key
Show all commands	ALT + I
Close window	ALT + Q
Minimize window	ALT + M
Focus left/right	ALT + H / L
Focus down/up	ALT + J / K
Move window left/right	ALT + Shift + H / L
Move window down/up	ALT + Shift + J / K
Toggle floating	ALT + D
Pause/unpause	ALT + P
Flip layout horizontal	ALT + X
Flip layout vertical	ALT + W
Switch workspace	ALT + 1–8
Move window to workspace	ALT + Shift + 1–8
Reload config	ALT + Shift + O

- Default layout is Binary Space Partitioning (BSP), each new window recursively splits the available space. Each workspace can run a different layout (side-by-side, stacked, etc.); this is set per-workspace in the JSON config, not via a single global toggle.
- The scrolling layout keeps a limited number of windows visible at once (3 by default), open another window and the oldest gets replaced. Change the maximum with komorebic scrolling-layout-columns 2 (or whatever number you want).
- Switching layouts within the same workspace requires editing config or using CLI commands (komorebic cycle-layout next), there’s no default keyboard shortcut out of the box. The built-in bar (--bar flag above) also lets you see and switch between layouts directly, see the yasb section below for another way to do this from a status bar widget.
- If the documentation is confusing (it can be, this is a config-file-first tool, not toggles-and-settings), a genuinely effective trick: import the entire Komorebi wiki into an AI tool that supports many-link ingestion (e.g. [NotebookLM](#) via its web-clipper extension) and ask it to explain specific config sections in plain language. The notebook linked above is the actual result of doing this.

- Autostart on boot: create a shortcut to `komorebi.exe` and drop it in your Startup folder (Win+R → `shell:startup`).

21. Status Bar, yasb (Yet Another Status Bar)

[INSTALL COMMAND]:

`winget install --id AmN.yasb -e`, or [download the installer directly](#).

Config paths:

```
%USERPROFILE%\config\yasb\config.yaml
%USERPROFILE%\config\yasb\styles.css
%USERPROFILE%\config\yasb\themes\
```

Resources: [yasb wiki](#) · [yasb widget docs](#) · [yasb theme gallery](#)

My config: [config.yaml](#) · [styles.css](#)

1. [Install](#) via the yasb reborn installer/app or through the winget command above.
2. Setup wizard: install missing fonts if prompted, enable tiling-window-manager support (select Komorebi), add starter widgets (CPU, memory, mic, media, quick launch), choose style (floating, opacity ~85%, blur).
3. yasb can conflict with the PowerToys Command Palette dock if both are enabled, disable one.
4. Once running, hide the native taskbar to save screen space: Settings → Personalization → Taskbar → Taskbar behaviors → Automatically hide the taskbar.
5. Adding widgets not in the starter set (e.g. [Komorebi control](#): start/stop/reload):
 - Install [VS Code](#) to edit the config comfortably, and open `config.yaml`.
 - Find the widget you want at [yasb.dev/widgets](#) and copy its “Example Configuration” block.
 - Paste the widget’s YAML block under the “widgets:” section. Like this:

widgets:

komorebi_control:

type: "komorebi_control"

label: " "

show_version: true

run_whkd: true

...

- Reference the new widget’s name under the relevant bar’s left/center/right list. Like this:

Bars:

widgets:

left:

- home

- quick launch

- **komorebi_control**

center:

- clock

right:

- media

- systray

- cpu

- memory

- If you want the widget to appear on the left part of the bar, paste it's name under the "left:" section. If you want it on the right paste it under the "right:" section. You need to use the exact same name that is used in the example configuration code.
 - Indentation errors are the most common failure, YAML is whitespace-sensitive; if you get a validation error, check whether the block needs to shift one tab left or right relative to its parent key.
 - Take a look at my config file to understand better what I'm talking about.
6. Useful additional widgets: a [taskbar widget](#) (shows open app windows in the bar itself, letting you fully replace the native taskbar), and a [Komorebi Layout](#) widget (shows/lets you switch Komorebi's current layout from the bar).
 7. Theming: check the system tray icon for a "Get Themes option. Back up your config.yaml before applying any theme, some (e.g. a popular "Fluent Design" theme) can break parts of the layout. If you only want one visual element from a broken theme (e.g. an animated pill-shaped workspace switcher), paste the full theme file into an AI assistant and ask it to isolate the relevant CSS rules, then merge just that into your own stylesheet rather than applying the whole theme.
 8. Right click system tray icon and click "Enable Autostart" to make it open on computer startup

Theme used in this build

The theme referenced above as the one that broke on full application is the **"Fluent Design"** theme from yasb's community catalog, the only piece kept from it was the pill-shaped workspace-switcher animation, extracted by hand as described in step 7. Browse it (and its known-compatible alternatives) at the [yasb theme gallery](#) or directly in the [yasb-themes repo](#), same "back up config.yaml first" caution applies to any theme you install from there.

22. Tacky Borders

My config: [config.yaml](#) · [community color presets](#)

1. [Download](#) a prebuilt release from the GitHub Releases page. **Config path:** %USERPROFILE%\config\tacky-borders\config.yaml
2. Run tacky-borders.exe for the first time, it auto-generates a config file for you. SmartScreen will likely flag it; More info → Run anyway.
3. Open config.yaml (via the system tray icon → right-click → “Show config”) to customize. Adds a colored outline to the currently focused window.
4. [Community color presets](#): a dedicated community GitHub repo of ready-made color preset files. From the main GitHub page, click the green Code button → Download ZIP (or just grab the “community color presets” link above), choose the gradient/color you want, open the folder, copy the config file, then right-click the tray icon → Show Config → paste it in.
5. Color choice tested and kept: a blue-to-turquoise gradient border, gradients read as more distinctive than a solid border color.
6. Bug: a stray blank/transparent outline appeared on screen that didn’t belong to any real window, it’s a key-visualizer overlay app (e.g. [KeyViz](#), see Tier 3) being misidentified as a window. **Fix:** exclude that process by name in Tacky Borders’ window_rules. This is actually already how Tacky Borders’ own default config ships, its auto-generated config.yaml already carries a matching rule (alongside a few other bar/overlay apps it knows to ignore, like zebars and seelen-ui), which is exactly why this fix worked:

```
window_rules:  
- match: Title  
  name: "keyviz"  
  enabled: False
```

If your outline is coming from a different overlay tool instead, swap in that process/window title and match on Process instead of Title if the title text is unreliable:

```
window_rules:  
- match: Process  
  name: "your-overlay-app"  
  enabled: False
```

7. If both Komorebi and Tacky Borders draw borders on the focused window simultaneously, disable Komorebi’s built-in border in its own config to avoid double borders: open %USERPROFILE%\komorebi.json and set "border": false.
8. Right-click the system tray icon → “Enable Autostart” so it launches on boot.

End state after Tier 2: debloated system, core app replacements, cleaned + augmented context menus, a chosen Start Menu replacement, custom sounds, and a fully tiling desktop via Komorebi + yasb + Tacky Borders.

TIER 3: The Twenty-Four-Hour Setup (Deep System Modification, Real Risk)

 This tier edits things Windows doesn't expect to be edited. Create a fresh System Restore Point. Back up anything irreplaceable. Ideally do this on a dual-boot/spare partition, not your daily driver.

23. Browser Overhaul: Zen Browser

1. Install Zen Browser (Firefox-based) and set as default.
2. Install [Sine](#) (community mod manager for Firefox-based browsers) from its [Releases page](#), grab [sine-win-x64.exe](#) if you're on Windows with a 64-bit CPU (if you're not sure, look up your CPU model).
 - If Windows Security deletes/flags the installer as malicious: Windows Security → Virus & threat protection → Manage settings → Add or remove exclusions → Add an exclusion → Folder → choose the folder the .exe gets saved to (usually Downloads) → re-download.
 - In Sine, select Zen Browser, choose your channel (e.g. Beta), and confirm the install path.
3. Install the [Nebula](#) theme through Sine (one click). Nebula's [recommended wallpaper pack](#) is available directly from its releases page.
4. Enable transparent tabs: go to `about:config` in Zen → search `browser.tabs.allow.transparent.browser` → set to `true`.
5. [Mica for Everyone](#) (separate system-wide app, GitHub). **[INSTALL COMMAND]:**
`winget install --id MicaForEveryone.MicaForEveryone -e`. Click “+ Add new rule” at the bottom left → Add process rule for zen:
 - Title bar color: dark.
 - Backdrop type: try Mica first, then Acrylic if performance suffers (Mica is visually nicer but noticeably heavier on some hardware, Acrylic is the safer default).
 - Enable “blur behind.”
 - Note: your Zen theme's contrast setting may need to be set to zero for the transparency to actually show through, check the theme's own docs if it looks opaque.
6. Install the “[Bonjournr](#)” extension for a custom new-tab page. To match the setup here, either follow the instructions on [Nebula's GitHub page](#) or download [bonjournr.json](#) directly, then in Bonjournr: settings button → scroll to the bottom → Import → select the file.
7. “Zen Internet” extension makes individual websites transparent against your wallpaper.

- First install the “[Transparent Zen](#)” mod, then the [Zen Internet](#) Firefox extension itself.
 - Open the extension’s pop-up and click “Refetch latest styles” to fetch the initial styles, and keep auto-update on to stay current.
 - Expect visual glitches on some sites, this is a known, documented limitation, not something you’re doing wrong.
 - Expect a real CPU/fan increase with this running, especially combined with a heavy Mica/Acrylic setup.
 - If straight transparency makes text hard to read against a busy wallpaper, right-click the Zen sidebar → Edit Theme and increase the overlay slider at the bottom for a dark, semi-transparent tint, trading a little “fully see-through” effect for something readable all day.
 - If text looks black-on-dark on a given site, that site either isn’t in dark theme or doesn’t have one. Fix with the [Dark Reader](#) extension.
8. [Untrap](#): a YouTube cleanup extension that hides homepage suggestions, Shorts, sidebar recommendations, end screens, and infinite scroll. Hiding Shorts didn’t work in testing.
 9. Zen’s built-in per-site Boosts (custom CSS/font per website): click the extensions icon next to the URL bar → Create new boost → apply custom fonts, text-transform, or hide specific elements (e.g. hide Discord’s sidebar) with simple CSS selectors.

Where to actually find more mods (cut from the video)

Zen Browser has its own [Discord server](#), this is where the entire mod ecosystem lives, not a random search. Join it and check the #showcase channel, sorted by most-engaged posts, for what the community is actually running.

Additional Sine mods worth trying, beyond Nebula:

- “Arc 2.0”, a competing theme styled after the (now-discontinued) Arc browser, with Arc-style animations and a different icon set. Its media player widget is arguably nicer than Nebula’s.
- Context Menu Icons, adds icons to Zen’s right-click context menu and folds/collapses redundant menu entries. Simple, safe, worth keeping.
- Super Pins, reworks the UI/UX of pinned tabs specifically (how they look and behave in the tab strip).
- Tab Closing Bubble Animation, adds a small bubble/explosion animation when you close a tab or an entire tab group. Purely cosmetic.
- Command Palette adds commands to the URL bar.
- Zen Tidy Tabs, uses Firefox’s built-in local AI to automatically sort/group your open tabs. Worth trying, but don’t expect it to be obvious out of the box, the trigger icon isn’t where

you'd guess (look for a small icon resembling a broom/wand in the toolbar), and the sorting logic isn't clearly documented, so treat it as an experiment rather than something you can configure precisely.

- A YouTube Music enhancement extension, restyles YouTube Music's now-playing bar with always-visible playback controls, custom backgrounds, and improved text readability.
- Inside Nebula's own theme settings (not Zen's native settings menu) you'll also find: a URL bar animation toggle (try disabling it if it looks buggy on your build), an option to disable the shadow around the web view, and the toggle that enables macOS-style window control buttons (the three colored dots instead of Windows minimize/maximize/close).

If you don't want to go down the full mod-by-mod rabbit hole above, Nebula + Zen Internet + Mica for Everyone (steps 1–8) already gets you 90% of the visual effect, treat the Arc 2.0/Tidy Tabs/pinned-tab mods as an optional “if you want to keep going” layer on top, not a requirement.

24. Windows Terminal Transparency

Settings → Profiles → Defaults (or a specific profile) → Appearance tab:

- Toggle “Enable acrylic material,” then adjust the background opacity slider. Expect to go back and forth on the number, legibility drops fast once other windows/apps are visible behind it.
- Optional font swap: install a Nerd Font (e.g. [FiraCode Nerd Font](#) or [CaskaydiaCove](#)) for terminal icon-glyph support, then set it under Appearance → Font face, and bump the font size (14 is a reasonable step up from default). Only worth doing if you plan to use a heavily-customized prompt, skip it if you're sticking with a plain terminal.
- Optional color scheme: the [Catppuccin](#) theme pack has ready-made scheme JSON files (e.g. Mocha) you paste into your settings.json under schemes, then select from Appearance → Color scheme.
- Skip [Starship/Oh My Posh](#) unless you're actually a developer who lives in the terminal, both require real setup (config files, a Nerd Font, sometimes Git) that isn't worth it if you rarely touch the terminal.
- Lighter-weight alternative that's actually worth doing: install the CTT (Chris Titus Tech) PowerShell Profile through WinUtil's Config tab. It gives you a nicer-looking, more useful default prompt without the full Starship/Oh-My-Posh setup.

25. Rectify 11

This whole cohesion chain (Rectify 11 → Mica for Everyone → Windhawk) follows the community-maintained “[Translucent Win 11](#)” guide on GitHub, worth reading directly, since it's kept up to date and is the actual source for this sequence.

1. Get the installer from the [official site](#), not GitHub Releases directly, at time of testing, the GitHub-hosted installer link errored out, while the project's own site worked.
2. ⚠ Version note: Rectify 11 was mid-rewrite (its "v4") at time of testing, with the GitHub README explicitly warning that v3 was no longer supported. Check which version you're actually installing before troubleshooting anything below.
3. Before installing, the installer instructs you to temporarily disable Windows Defender/your antivirus (Real-time protection, Cloud-delivered protection, and Tamper Protection) and re-enable all three afterward, excluding the Rectify 11 install folder from future scans.
4. Accept the license agreement, then choose what to install. Install everything for the full effect: System Icons, Basic and Advanced Themes, and under Extras, Enhanced Context Menu, Rectified Gadgets, Accent Color Colorizing, Rectify 11 Wallpapers, and Remastered User Avatars.
5. For the context menu option, you're offered "Enhanced Fluent Menu" or "Enhanced Fluent Menu with all items in root" (the latter shows more items in the "more options" dropdown), pick whichever density you prefer, you can always restyle or revert this later (see step 11 below).
6. The installer tells you to close everything and save your work; a reboot is required at the end. It also offers to create a restore point as part of the install flow, take it.
7. Installation is slow, budget 10+ minutes. It can run in the background while you do other things.
8. After install, open "Rectify 11 Control Center" from the Start menu. If it throws an error immediately after install, that's expected before the reboot, it works normally once you've restarted.
9. After restart, a blank white/transparent window may appear locked to the bottom of the screen, that's KeyViz again, rendering a blank frame. Close the app.
10. Startup conflict: Rectify 11 starts its own instance of Mica for Everyone automatically. If you also have your own separate Mica for Everyone launching on startup, you'll get two conflicting instances, disable one (Task Manager → Startup apps).
11. Rectify 11 Settings (from its desktop notification, or Control Panel):
 - Theme options: differences between some are subtle; dark theme with Mica is a safe, well-tested default.
 - Context menu style: if you don't like whichever Enhanced Fluent Menu option you picked during install, go to Rectify 11 Settings → "Change settings that are unavailable" → set context menu back to Windows 11 Default → restart Explorer.
 - Light theme is currently broken: large portions of system text become unreadable in the light variant. Stick to dark.

26. Nilesoft Shell, Full Context Menu Replacement

1. Install Nilesoft Shell if not already present.

[INSTALL COMMAND]: `winget install --id Nilesoft.Shell -e`

Config paths:

C:\Program Files\Nilesoft Shell\shell.nss,
C:\Program Files\Nilesoft Shell\imports\
C:\Program Files\Nilesoft Shell\themes\.

Resources: [Nilesoft docs \(archived\)](#) · [my YouTube video on Nilesoft Shell customization](#) · [Nilesoft Shell's Discord server](#)

My config files, drop these into C:\Program Files\Nilesoft Shell\:

- [shell.nss](#)

- [nss.mode.nss](#) (the snippet that lets you switch between Nilesoft's menu and the native Windows menu)

...and these into C:\Program Files\Nilesoft Shell\imports\:

- [modify.nss](#) (moves or removes menu items)

- [theme.nss](#) (controls the look, font size, color, etc.)

Manual customization (edit shell.nss directly):

1. Set font size with `font.size=40` placed under `image.align=2`. The default size of 14 reads too small at 4K, the DSR upscaling from Tier 1 shrinks everything, so a bigger value compensates.

2. Disable submenus you don't use in `imports\shell.nss` by prefixing the line with `//` (comments it out in .nss syntax). The two disabled here: "Go To" (quick navigation to frequently-used folders) and "Develop" (opens Command Prompt/Terminal from the context menu), e.g. `//import 'imports/terminal.nss'`. Save and Ctrl+Right-click again to confirm the submenu is gone before moving on.

3. In `imports\modify.nss` you can reorder or remove individual items, add these at the bottom of the file like this:

- Reorder: `modify(find="Blip" pos=30)`

- Remove: `remove(find="Scan with Microsoft Defender")`

4. Useful [community snippets](#): a macOS-style menu theme (same `theme.nss` linked above), a [toggle to switch between Nilesoft's menu and the native Windows menu on demand](#), a snippet that shows [keyboard shortcuts next to supported actions](#), and a [batch-rename tool](#) (prefix/casing options) added directly to the context menu.

5. Keep a backup of a working shell.nss. If future tweaks break it, restoring from your own backup is far faster than rebuilding from scratch.

You can find more themes and additional resources in Nilesoft shell discord server:

<https://discord.gg/abmJ9kdQt>

27. Windhawk, Mod Marketplace

[INSTALL COMMAND]: winget install --id RamenSoftware.Windhawk -e, then install mods individually from its in-app store.

Recommended set, in the order they build on each other:

Cohesion / translucency chain (from the community “[Translucent Win 11](#)” guide)

1. Taskbar Clock Customization, custom taskbar clock. I prefer it over eleven clock.
2. Taskbar Tray System Icon Tweaks, hide unneeded tray icons (e.g. language indicator).
3. Windows 11 Notification Center Styler, applied a translucent theme (There are other variants: liquid glass, tinted glass, borderless).
4. Windows 11 Start Menu Styler, translucent theme. May be slow to open initially; restarting Explorer after applying usually fixes lag.
5. Taskbar Styler, match the taskbar to the Start Menu/Notification Center theme for visual consistency.
6. File Explorer Styler, apply visual theme presets to File Explorer itself. Several presets are available; “Tabless” is worth trying first, it reads as clean and uncluttered without looking unfinished, and was the pick that stuck in testing.

Utility mods:

- Folder Sizes in File Explorer Details, Shift+click a folder in Details view to see its total size.
- F2 rename behavior fix, first F2 press selects only the filename (not extension); second press selects the extension; triple-click selects everything.
- Dark Mode Context Menus, forces legacy menu bars to render dark even on apps that try to force light mode (like Premiere Pro or Photoshop).
- Middle Click to Close, middle-click (scroll wheel) a taskbar icon to instantly close that app.
- Instant Taskbar Autohide Speed, tune animation frame rate (try 144 FPS) and separate show/hide speed values (hide speed around 125 tends to feel like a good balance vs. the sluggish default).
- Taskbar Start Button Always on Left, pins Start to the left while keeping other icons centered.

- Click on Empty Taskbar Space, bind custom actions (with keyboard modifiers) to clicks on empty taskbar space, e.g. Ctrl+Left-click to toggle combined/uncombined taskbar buttons, or open Task Manager.

A handful of small quality-of-life mods, easy to miss because each does one tiny thing:

- Bigger taskbar thumbnails, enlarges the hover-preview thumbnails when you hover a taskbar icon.

- Pie chart for folder properties, right-click a folder → Properties shows disk usage as a pie chart instead of the default flat bar.

- Double-click empty space in File Explorer to go up one folder level, instead of only working via the back button/backspace.

- Scroll wheel over a taskbar app icon minimizes/restores it, a fast alternative to clicking. - None of these are individually essential, but they're free, low-risk, and arguably things that should be built into Windows already, worth grabbing all four in one pass through the Windhawk store.

- Nilessoft Shell Animator, customizable context menu animations. Test modes: Slide, Fade, or Fade + Slide combined (i prefer it). Tune slide distance (~20px, not 200, too far feels too slow) and duration (~300ms is a good balance; 1000ms feels sluggish, near-zero feels like no animation at all).

- Disable Virtual Desktop Transition Animation, add dwm.exe to the mod's custom process inclusion list to make virtual-desktop switching instant instead of a slow slide.

- Slick Window Arrangement, adds a sliding animation when a window is moved or snapped. Not designed to work with Komorebi and conflicted with it in testing, install if you're curious what it looks like, but expect to disable it again if you're running a tiling window manager. Skip entirely if Komorebi is already part of your build.

- Bar Dock Animation, adds a macOS-dock-style bounce animation to taskbar icons on click. Was still in beta at time of testing, install if you want to try it, but don't expect full polish yet.

- Translucent Windows mod, converts many app backgrounds to a consistent Mica look system-wide (rather than raw transparency), which is generally more legible.

- Resource Redirect, swaps system icon packs. Icon packs to try: monochrome/all-white sets, "Symbolic," "Big Sur Dark," or the one I stuck with BUFF. - ⚠️ This is the mod most likely to cause serious system instability (see the troubleshooting section below), apply one icon pack at a time and confirm stability before trying another.

- After switching packs, if icons don't update everywhere: Open Wintoys Health tab and use the icon-cache-rebuild option. Expect that some icons still won't fully refresh until a full sign-out/restart.

Custom Start Menu layouts:

- [VinStar Themes](#) host JSON configs for alternate layouts, including a “[Windows 12](#)” style layout showing pinned apps and the full app list simultaneously.
- Apply via Windhawk → Start Menu Styler mod → Advanced tab → paste the JSON.
- If a section header renders clipped/cut off, the usual culprit is a negative margin value in the theme CSS, feed the snippet to an AI assistant and ask it to identify and correct the offending margin value. [This is the fixed code](#).

28. Mica for Everyone, Global Rule

[INSTALL COMMAND]: `winget install --id MicaForEveryone.MicaForEveryone -e`

Beyond per-app rules (used above for Zen, qBittorrent, etc.), you can set a global rule so nearly every app gets Mica/Acrylic treatment automatically: dark title bar, Mica backdrop type, rounded corners preference, “extend frame into client area,” enable blur behind.

Known limitation: some apps render oddly under a blanket global rule. Fix conflicts individually by adding a per-app exception rule with the effect disabled for that specific process.

29. Explorer Patcher, Proceed With Caution, Expect Failure

This modifies the Windows shell process directly and is the highest-risk tool in this guide.

[INSTALL COMMAND]: `winget install --id valinet.ExplorerPatcher -e`

Before installing: confirm Smart App Control is OFF (Settings → Privacy & security → Windows Security → App & browser control, if enabled, it cannot be turned back off without a clean install, so verify before you enable anything, not after). The project’s own installer explicitly warns not to install on machines running SentinelOne (an enterprise endpoint-security product), check for that if you’re on a work or managed device. Current Windows Defender no longer flags Explorer Patcher, so manual Defender exclusions generally aren’t needed anymore, but third-party antivirus/security software might still need its own exclusion added for the install folder.

1. Run the installer.
2. First run shows a notification: “Downloading symbols for OS build. Please wait. This may take several minutes. Explorer Patcher may have limited and/or broken functionality” until it completes. Expect the taskbar, and possibly the entire shell, including the browser, to briefly stop responding during this window. This is common, not unique to your setup.
3. If Windhawk pops up a “System instability detected, might be caused by one of the Windhawk mods” dialog around this same time, don’t chase it inside Windhawk, in testing this was a false lead; the instability was actually caused by Explorer Patcher.

Close the dialog and keep troubleshooting Explorer Patcher itself (e.g. a Terminal restart of Explorer) rather than disabling Windhawk mods one by one.

4. In Explorer Patcher's settings, you can try switching the taskbar style (Windows 10 vs. 11) and window switcher (default vs. "Simple Window Switcher"). Other settings worth exploring:
 - Use classic drive groupings in This PC: leave off, not worth the visual clutter.
 - Use immersive menus: on (for Windows 10-style context menus).
 - Shrink address bar height: on, reclaims a bit of vertical space in Explorer.
 - Mica effect for the navigation bar: on, for consistency with the rest of a Mica-themed build.
 - Start menu style: Windows 11.
 - Disable recommended section: on (redundant if already done via WinUtil/Start Settings in Tier 2, confirm it's still off here too).
 - Maximum frequent apps shown: 10.
 - Alt-Tab theme: test opacity around 95%; corner preference options are subtle enough that they "all look about the same" in practice.
 - Show desktop as the last window in the interaction list: on.
 - Display switcher on primary monitor only: on (irrelevant on single-monitor setups).
 - Group windows by the same app: on.
5. Known unresolved issue: "Simple Window Switcher" frequently stops rendering entirely after a short time (windows still switch in the background, but no UI shows), this appears to be a compatibility gap with certain Windows 11 builds rather than something fixable through settings. Restarting Explorer, reinstalling, and disabling other shell mods to rule out conflicts are reasonable troubleshooting steps, but there's currently no guaranteed fix. If you hit this, uninstalling and skipping Explorer Patcher is a legitimate outcome, not a failure on your part.

30. System Font Replacement

- [WinPaletter](#), a broad theming tool (colors, cursors, sounds, metrics/fonts, wallpaper, screensaver, icons, window effects). **[INSTALL COMMAND]:** `winget install --id Abdelrhman-AK.WinPaletter -e`
 - Before applying anything, turn on its safety net: enable "always create a Windows Restore Point before applying a theme" and turn on automated theme backups in its settings.
 - Metrics and Fonts is the standout feature: set a custom system font (e.g. SF Pro Display, Medium weight, size 12) applied to classic UI elements and, where possible, window title bars.
 - Window Effects tab: customize the open/close/minimize/maximize window animations, a smoother or snappier animation set here is one of the more noticeable "feel" improvements in the whole build.

- Small extra worth grabbing: a checkbox to make dialog boxes automatically snap the cursor to the default button when a dialog opens (e.g. jumps straight to “OK”/“Yes”). Small, but saves a lot of tiny mouse movements over time.
- Icons section: if you’ve already customized icons via Windhawk’s Resource Redirect (Tier 3, step 27) or another icon-pack tool, this section is redundant, skip it rather than layering two icon tools.
- Known limitation: window title bar fonts specifically cannot be changed on Windows 11, they’ll stay Segoe UI regardless of what you set elsewhere.
- Legacy tools (Event Viewer, Disk Management, etc.) often render the custom font inconsistently or not at all, expect visual mismatches in older Control Panel-era utilities.
- [NoMeiryoUI](#), install from GitHub Releases, the same font customization feature as WinPaletter.
 - Changing the font here affects more than you’d expect: it can also change the rendered font inside Chromium- and Firefox-based browsers (e.g. Zen Browser’s UI and new-tab page picked up the change in testing), not just classic Windows dialogs.
 - Test a few options before committing: try a coding-oriented font like JetBrains Mono first (a useful gut-check for legibility), then try Microsoft’s own newer system font, [Aptos](#) (download from Microsoft’s official site, install the extracted font files, select it in NoMeiryoUI at size 12). Aptos rendered cleanly in both Disk Management and Event Viewer during testing, with no visible mismatch.

31. Rebound 11, Limited Practical Value

Aims to replace legacy Windows utilities with modern Fluent-styled versions, Cleanup on Screen (Disk Cleanup replacement), UAC Settings, Rebound Chill, Rebound About, Rebound Service Host, Rebound Disk Cleanup, Rebound Shell Hub (a Control Panel replacement), and User Account Control.

Current state: mostly non-functional. Run the installer, then launch “Rebound Hub” from the Start menu, the collection point for all the above apps. Most flash briefly on screen and close instead of actually opening. The Shell Hub / Control Panel replacement works but adds little over just using Settings directly. Rebound Disk Cleanup opens and looks genuinely nice, but doesn’t reliably delete anything. Install if curious; don’t expect it to replace anything in your daily workflow yet, treat it as a “worth checking back on in six months” tool rather than something to build around now.

32. App-Level Theming (Fluent-Consistent Look)

- [OBS Studio](#):

[INSTALL COMMAND] `winget install --id OBSProject.OBSStudio -e`

Apply a “[Fluent Dark \(Grey\)](#)” theme (Tools → or via a downloaded .qss/theme file, per OBS’s theme documentation).

- [BetterDiscord](#): install (accept the license agreement in its installer), then open Discord → Settings → scroll to the BetterDiscord section → Themes tab. Search “Fluent” and compare Fluent (~56K downloads), Discord 11 (~92.5K downloads), and Discord Mica (~80K downloads), note that even “Mica” didn’t actually deliver a Mica blur effect in testing, reading visually as just a dark theme with rounded corners. Fluent is generally the most complete match to a Windows 11 aesthetic.
 - Only enable one theme at a time. Enabling a second theme on top of an existing one is the most likely cause if the whole BetterDiscord section disappears from Settings after restarting Discord. Fix: reinstall BetterDiscord if needed, open Themes, disable all themes, then enable only the one you want.
- [VS Code](#): install “[Fluent UI for VS Code \(Continued\)](#)”, the original “Fluent UI” extension is abandoned and breaks on current VS Code builds; the “Continued” community fork is the one that works. After enabling via Command Palette (Ctrl+Shift+P → “Fluent UI: Enable”), VS Code prompts to restart and may show a generic “installation appears corrupt” warning, this is expected/benign, dismiss it.
- [qBittorrent](#): **[INSTALL COMMAND]**: `winget install --id qBittorrent.qBittorrent -e`. Download a “[Fluent Theme](#)” for qBittorrent’s UI → View → Options → check “Use custom UI theme” → select the downloaded theme file → restart the app. Add a Mica for Everyone process rule for qBittorrent’s .exe: Mica backdrop, dark title bar, extend frame into client area, but leave “enable blur behind” off if the theme’s own documentation recommends it (some Fluent themes are tuned for pure Mica without extra blur).

33. Rainmeter, Optional, Often Skipped

A classic desktop-widget engine (system stats, music controls, clocks) with a huge back-catalog of community “skins” dating back to the early 2000s, genuinely “the OG of Windows customization,” predating most tools in this guide by close to two decades.

[INSTALL COMMAND]: `winget install --id Rainmeter.Rainmeter -e`, then search for skins separately, the skin marketplace is community-run and separate from the core app.

- “[Square Player](#)” is a solid one to start with for a media-player-style widget. Download the skin package → right-click the extracted .rmskin file → “Install Rainmeter Skin” → relaunch Rainmeter → right-click the tray icon → Skins → select a variant (Square Player ships with multiple layouts, e.g. S1 through S4, try a few, they’re different arrangements of the same widget).
- Worth knowing about, but many modern skins visually clash with a Fluent/Mica-consistent setup built through the rest of this guide, a Rainmeter skin will likely look dated by comparison once everything else is in place. It’s completely reasonable to install one, look at it for a minute, and decide not to actively use it.

34. Miscellaneous Shell/Desktop Replacements

- [Cairo Desktop](#) adds a macOS-style top menu bar plus a pop-up file browser overlay. Known limitation: drag-and-drop from its file browser into other apps (e.g. Discord) doesn't work, nor does copy-paste from it in some configurations.
- [SeelenUI](#), a full desktop environment replacement (taskbar + launcher + desktop shell in one). ⚠ Can cause visible screen glitching immediately on launch for some hardware/driver combinations, have a restart ready if you try it, and don't make it your first deep-shell-replacement experiment (do Explorer Patcher's lessons first).
- [Windowsill](#), a contextual file-action bar.
- [ClipShelf](#), a clipboard manager. Both are lightweight and low-risk, and arguably should be installed earlier (Tier 2) alongside other quality-of-life tools rather than saved for last.

The Full Startup Checklist (What Actually Has to Launch Every Boot)

This part never made it into the video, but it's the single most useful thing for actually living with a build this deep: the complete list of everything that needs to be running simultaneously for the full look to come together, in the order that avoids most conflicts. Use this as your post-restart checklist, and as your autostart list (Task Manager → Startup apps, or shortcuts in shell:startup) once you're happy with the setup.

1. Set your final wallpaper first (everything else layers on top visually).
2. Your core app replacements: Screenbox, UniGetUI, Fluent Weather, File Pilot (with your chosen theme).
3. Traffic Monitor.
4. UWidgets.
5. Fluent Flyout (media/volume overhaul).
6. Sound Manager, apply your final sound scheme.
7. Start All Back, confirm your Explorer style settings held (Mica, new icons, colorize with accent, dark mode, bottom details pane, restored Control Panel applets), these can occasionally reset after a Windows update.
8. Komorebi, launch with `-whkd` so hotkeys actually work (see Tier 2, step 20 for the exact autostart command).
9. Tacky Borders.
10. Zen Browser.
11. Rectify 11.
12. Nilessoft Shell.
13. Windhawk.
14. Your themed daily apps: Discord (BetterDiscord + Fluent theme), VS Code (Fluent UI extension), qBittorrent (Fluent Dark theme + Mica for Everyone rule).

15. Anything else you kept from the “optional/rarely used” list, Rainmeter, Cairo Desktop, Windowsill, ClipShelf, only if you actually decided to keep them running day to day.

Starting point for this checklist: right before running through it, a clean restart with everything closed should land around 114 processes, ~20% CPU, and ~4.5GB RAM, a genuinely fast, responsive baseline even after everything installed across all three tiers. That number climbing back up as you launch each tool below is expected; it’s what you’re trading for the full look.

Reality check on resource cost at full load: expect CPU usage to spike into the 80–110%+ range and RAM to climb past 10-12GB with all of this launching at once, easing back down to something much more reasonable (~20% CPU, well under half your RAM) once everything settles and idles. If your system feels sluggish for the first minute or two after login with this much autostarting, that’s expected, it’s not a sign something’s broken.

Critical Troubleshooting: When Windows Itself Breaks

Deep icon-pack swaps (Resource Redirect) and shell-level tools (Explorer Patcher) carry real risk of corrupting system files. If you start seeing cascading errors, a tiling manager failing to launch, graphics driver updates failing with vague “please try again later” errors, or built-in tools like DiskPart refusing to open, work through this escalation path in order:

1. Free up disk space first, driver installers often fail (misleadingly) when space is tight. Rule this out before assuming deeper corruption.
2. Run System File Checker: open Terminal as Administrator → `sfc /scannow`. Let it finish completely (don’t interrupt it, a corrupted or interrupted mid-scan run is a real risk if you’re also screen-recording at the time). Watch for: “Windows Resource Protection found corrupt files but was unable to fix some of them.” That message means step 2 alone isn’t enough, move to step 3.
3. Run DISM, a deeper repair tool that can fix issues SFC can’t reach:

```
DISM /Online /Cleanup-Image /RestoreHealth
```

Run as Administrator. Typically takes 10–20 minutes. It’s common for this to end with “The requested operation failed; a system reboot is required to roll back changes”, that’s expected, not a failure. Reboot when it tells you to.

4. Re-run `sfc /scannow` once more after the reboot, to confirm the repair held. In practice, this full sequence (SFC → DISM → reboot) is what actually resolves it, driver installs, tiling managers, and previously-broken tools all started working again immediately after.
5. If a specific tool (Resource Redirect, Explorer Patcher, SeelenUI) was the last thing installed before instability appeared, uninstall it before reapplying anything else,

and apply future icon-pack/shell changes one at a time with a restart and stability check in between, not in a batch.

General rule for this entire tier: if a built-in Windows tool (DiskPart, driver installer, Explorer itself) starts failing with a generic/unhelpful error message right after installing something new, treat it as a system-file-integrity issue first (sfc → DISM), not a settings problem, chasing settings toggles when the underlying files are corrupted wastes time.

Quick-Reference: Full Tool List by Tier

Tier 1: [Nvidia Control Panel](#) (DSR/Digital Vibrance), [Timeline Wallpaper](#), [WinToys](#), [Vision Cursor](#) (GitHub), [PowerToys](#), [TranslucentTB](#)

Tier 2: [WinUtil](#) (Chris Titus Tech), [UniGetUI](#), [Screenbox](#), [Fluent Weather](#), [File Pilot](#), [Desktop Pets](#), [Fliqlo](#), [Task Separator 11](#), [RoundedTB](#), [Traffic Monitor](#), [ElevenClock](#), [UWidgets](#), [Accent Colorizer + Accent Colorizer 11](#), [Fluent Flyout](#), [TopNotify](#), [Lively Wallpaper](#) / [Sucrose](#), [Sound Manager](#), [Mechvibes/Thockly](#), [Folder 11](#) (unreliable), [Windows 11 Context Menu Manager](#), [Context Menu Manager](#) (Custom CMC), [Start 11](#) / [Start All Back](#), [Komorebi](#), [yasb](#), [Tacky Borders](#)

Tier 3: [Zen Browser](#), [Sine](#) (mod manager), [Nebula](#) theme, [Mica for Everyone](#), Zen Internet extension, [Untrap](#), [Rectify 11](#), [Windhawk](#) (multiple mods), [Nilessoft Shell](#), [Explorer Patcher](#) (high risk, may fail), [WinPaletter](#) / [NoMeiryoUI](#), [Rebound 11](#) (limited value), [BetterDiscord](#), [Fluent UI for VS Code \(Continued\)](#), [qBittorrent](#) Fluent theme, [Rainmeter](#) (optional), [Cairo Desktop](#), [SeelenUI](#) (risk of glitching), [Windowsill](#), [ClipShelf](#), [KeyViz](#)

Final Note on Resource Cost

By the end of Tier 3 with everything running simultaneously, expect CPU usage in the 80–110%+ range at idle, 10+ GB of RAM in use, and 200+ background processes. None of this is meant to run all at once as a daily driver. If you're building this for actual daily use rather than as an experiment, Tier 1 alone, sharper rendering, a custom cursor, decluttered widgets, PowerToys, delivers most of the practical improvement with essentially none of the risk or overhead. Treat Tiers 2 and 3 as a menu to pick individual tools from, not a checklist to run in full.
